THE HIGH-STAKES BATTLE

The stakes are extremely high for both the national parties. For the BJP, Karnataka is the only southern state where it has a major share of the seats both in the Lok Sabha and in the state assembly. Of the 28 Lok Sabha seats in the state, the BJP has 25. And in the current assembly, of the 224 seats, the BJP has 118, though it achieved a majority only after inducting 17 defectors from the Congress and the Janata Dal (Secular) or the JD(S) a year after the 2018 polls. Of the 130 Lok Sabha seats in the six southern states—namely, Karnataka, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry—the BJP has 29, and nearly 90 per cent of those are from Karnataka. Again, barring Karnataka, the party is a minor player in the state assemblies in all the other five states. For the BJP, a win in Karnataka will boost its campaign in neighbouring Telangana, which goes to the polls this December. As Bommai told INDIA TODAY, "A fierce battle is on. While Karnataka is a do-or-die election for the Congress, it is a must-win for the BJP."

Former chief minister Siddaramaiah, who is a frontrunner for his party, the Congress, scoffs at Bommai and his style of governance, but agrees with his opponent's assessment that the elections are critical to the future of both parties. Dressed in a white kurta and with his trademark stubble beard, the 75-year-old speaks candidly, unmindful of the crowd of party workers in his office. "The BJP's aim is to win in South India," he says. "For us in the Congress, from a national perspective, we must protect our strength in Karnataka by winning the election. It will lead to Congress revival at the national level and be a stepping stone for the 2024 general election." Ironically, both Siddaramaiah and Bommai were compatriots in the erstwhile Janata Dal before the party split into the present-day components—the JD(S) and the Janata Dal (United) or JD(U)—in 1999. Siddaramaiah joined the JD(S) headed by former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda and then the Congress in 2006. Bommai preferred the JD(U) before joining the BJP in 2008.

Switching party loyalties in Karnataka is a common phenomenon, with psephologist Sandeep Shastri of Lokniti-CSDS pointing out that one in every six MLAs in the current assembly has been elected on more than one party ticket in their career. Meanwhile, the JD(S) continues to be a force to reckon with in the Old Mysuru region, which accounts for 67 seats. In addition to garnering 18-20 per cent of the vote in the state, it wins 30-40 seats on an average. These numbers become important if neither of the two big parties gets a majority on their own as has been the case in the recent past. The JD(S) then emerges as the kingmaker and, at times, its leader H.D. Kumaraswamy even becomes the king. In 2006 and 2018, even though the JD(S) had 58 and 40 seats, respectively, Kumaraswamy was anointed chief minister after joining hands once with the BJP and then with the Congress, though his tenure lasted barely two years in each term. The BJP and the Congress are now wary of having the JD(S) steal their thunder again and are working towards getting a decisive verdict.

BJP'S LEADERSHIP DILEMMA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi met Bommai just before the election campaign, and reportedly asked his chief minister, "How are you feeling about the election?" When Bommai said he felt confident, Modi persisted. "Are you very confident, overconfident or carefully confident?" "Carefully confident," Bommai told him. To which, the PM said, "You have a big task on your hand." Agreeing with him, Bommai acknowledged, "Yes, the challenge is there." Modi then advised him to be well-prepared and plan the electoral strategy at the micro level.

That shouldn't be tough for the now balding 63-year-old Bommai, who walks with a limp. Behind his affable demeanour lies a shrewd and meticulous mind. In consultation with the party high command, he had already laid much of the groundwork months before the electioneering process began. Bommai was acutely aware that despite the BJP having two major shots at ruling the state in the past 15 years, including his tenure, when it came to total seats, the party had never won a majority on its own. The maximum it secured was 110 in 2008—three short of a simple majority in the 224-seat state assembly.

A TRIANGULAR CONTEST

CONGRESS

It is the only party to have got a clear majority not just once but twice in the past five assembly elections in Karnataka. Despite a failed coalition with the JD(S) in 2004-06, it let its junior ally lead the government in 2018, only to see it collapse in the space of a year.

BJP

Karnataka is the only southern state where the BJP has come to power, its four CMs having had a cumulative term of nearly nine years. But the party has never got a clear majority, despite being the single largest one thrice since 2004. Post defections, its strength went up from 104 to the current 118.



JANATA DAL (SECULAR)

Its origins lie in the Janata Party, which formed the first non-Congress government in Karnataka in the '80s, but the JD(S) has never been able to achieve similar heights since its formation in 1999. Its vote share has been stagnating around 20 per cent despite short-lived stints in power in coalition with both the Congress and the BJP.